



WISHING YOU & YOUR FAMILY A
HAPPY AND HEALTHY PESACH!

THE FIFTEEN
STEPS OF THE
PESACH
SEDER

1. KADESH

reciting Kiddush

We start the Seder with making a blessing over a cup of wine. Kadesh means to sanctify – we sanctify G-d's name and the wine by blessing it. Kadesh also means 'to separate,' referring to the separation between good and bad, holy and profane. The first step of the Seder process is to create a new space so that the journey toward freedom can begin. **We separate ourselves from the mundane past that enslaves us** and enter the sacred spiritual experience of the Seder which frees us.

2. U'RCHATZ

washing the hands

We wash our hands before dipping a vegetable (Karpas) in saltwater. Following the separation between the mundane and the sacred, we wash and submerge our hands in water, **cleansing our 'tools'** in preparation for the following steps.

3. KARPAS

eating a vegetable dipped in salt water

The vegetable represents our body, which comes from the dust and the salt water represents the salty tears shed in times of pain. Salt is a cleanser, and tears are an expression of the soul. We cleanse our bodies with our soul's tears. **The material** world is like a 'vegetable' that needs to be **dipped in spiritual** salt water. Karpas reminds us that the body is merely a means, not an end in itself. The body's purpose is to transcend the world that it lives in, by connecting itself to the soul.

4. YACHATZ

breaking the middle matzah

After we have the "Karpas" awareness, we actually release ourselves from materialism by breaking the Matzoh, **symbolizing "bittul", suspending oneself** for a higher purpose. The antithesis of Matzah is chometz (leavened bread). Chometz is bread that is allowed to rise. This represents the inflated ego, which is mostly "air." Matzah on the other hand is just flour and water without any inflated air. Matzah empowers us with bittul, the ability to transcend your own viewpoint and allow in a higher truth.

14. HALLEL

reciting psalms of praise

Hallel also means '**to shine,**' from the expression 'behilo nero – when his candle shone forth.' Hallel is recited on those occasions when G-d's truth shines forth into our material world, revealing and manifesting that G-dliness is the ultimate. Through these words of praise we place ourselves in G-d's hands. We surrender to G-d to complement whatever we cannot do on our own and to conclude the process of reaching complete freedom.

15. NIRTZAH

G-d's promise to accept our service

Unlike the previous 14 steps, this last and final step does not manifest itself in any prayer or action. We have reached a point that transcends words and praise. After we have completed our Seder service, we are **accepted favorably by G-d.**

As such we are ready for the final and complete freedom and redemption. **NEXT YEAR IN JERUSALEM!**



RABBI SCHNEUR ZALMAN OF LIADI, THE ALTER REBBE, DID NOT INCLUDE AT THE CONCLUSION OF THE HAGGADAH THE PASSAGE 'THE ORDER OF PESACH IS CONCLUDED,' BECAUSE THE PASSOVER SEDER NEVER ENDS. INSTEAD, IT CONTINUES THROUGHOUT THE YEAR. TO BE SURE, THE ILLUMINATION OF EVERY FESTIVAL RADIATES EVERY DAY; BUT PESACH EXTENDS CONTINUOUSLY. EVERY DAY WE MUST LEAVE MITZRAYIM, TRANSCEND OUT PREVIOUS LIMITATIONS AND REACH HIGHER LEVELS OF HOLINESS.

9. MAROR

eating the bitter herbs

The eating of Matzo brings our mission into the real world. Once in the real world we find challenges from our oppressors. The bitter maror teaches us **the power of perseverance**. An olive does not produce oil until it is pressed. So too, maror hardens our mettle – the setbacks and pain in life strengthen us. Like steel that is hardened in fire and heat.

10. KORECH

eating a sandwich of Matzah and Maror

We now unite both the Matzoh and maror experience all in one sandwich. We combine both the matzo's earthiness and humility and the maror's bitterness. **There is a time to sing and a time to cry.** A time to celebrate and a time to feel the harshness of life. A time for the sweet and a time for the bitter. We learn to join them into one seamless experience called life – the mission for which we are sent here by G-d. And then we have freedom.

11. SHULCHAN ARUCH

lit. 'set table' – eating the festive meal

And now, finally, we are ready... to eat. After the first 10 steps (corresponding to the ten sefirot) of training to integrate spiritual freedom into our material lives, we are now ready for **the first real test**: Eating an entire material in an entirely new way, one permeated with a sense of Higher presence and G-dliness.

12. TZAFUN

eating the Afikoman

We eat the afikoman-the half of the middle Matzoh that we broke and then hid away in Yachatz #4. Tzofon means **'hidden.'** It also means 'north,' where it's cold and seemingly void of spirituality. After we have eaten the meal as free people, a material meal eaten in a spiritual and refined way, we now have the power to reveal that which is hidden & unconscious–tzofon – within ourselves and involve it with holiness.

13. BERACH

reciting the grace after meal

We conclude the meal with reciting grace. The meal is thus punctuated by the two spiritual poles – the first ten steps prior to the meal and the grace said after the meal. This gives us the power to ensure that the meal – which is symbolic of all our material experiences – will **yield the spiritual energy** that lies within its Divine sparks.

5. MAGGID

reciting the Haggadah

After the first four preliminary steps are in place, we now have earned the right to actually tell (Maggid) and relive the story of Exodus. Maggid includes the largest part of the Haggadah.

Telling the story – Maggid – begins with the child (inner and outer) asking the Four Questions. As mentioned above, the first and perhaps greatest freedom of all is the freedom to ask questions. To probe, explore and challenge. Not only are we free to ask, we must ask. Healthy questions are an **expression of the search** and the striving for something higher, reaching for a place that is beyond us. If you are complacent and not curious, you remain stuck in your own space. Questions allow us **the opportunity to truly grow**.

6. RACHTZAH

washing the hands for Matzah

Once we are elevated to a higher level of holiness through the first five steps, we need to submerge our hands once again in water, preparing ourselves for the next stage of spiritual growth and freedom. We live in a material world, and for freedom to be complete in this world it needs to be, not just psychological, but expressed in a real and tangible way, where **the material world** no longer holds us hostage and the material is transformed and even **becomes a vehicle for spirituality**.

7. MOTZI

reciting the blessing "HaMotzi Lechem"

We begin the process of transformation with Motzi: the first blessing, blessing G-d, 'who brings forth bread from the earth.' Lechem-bread also means 'to battle.' **A meal is like a war** between the material and the spiritual sparks that lie hidden within the food, between our temptation to indulge and our ability to elevate the material meal by using the energy we receive for good.

8. MATZAH

the blessing for the Mitzvah of Matzoh and eating it

Then we bless eat the matzah. We ingest it and make it part of our body, sustaining our body and soul. You assume what you consume. By eating and consuming matzah – the food of bittul – we assume its qualities. As the Rebbe MaHaRash writes, **eating matzah is like 'eating G-dliness.'** On the first night of Passover matzah is called the "bread of faith." On the second night it is called "bread of healing."